

7 WEBSITE PROBLEMS

That Quietly Cost Businesses Customers

A Short, Straight-Talking Guide for Business Owners

Written by Romany R. — Web Developer

Before We Start

I want to be upfront about something: I'm not writing this to lecture you about “best practices” you've already heard a hundred times. Every business owner I've ever talked to has been told to “have a strong online presence” by someone who couldn't explain what that actually means in practice.

So instead, I'm going to walk you through the problems I actually look for when I open up a business's website for the first time — the things that, within seconds, tell me whether that business is going to win or lose the customer who just landed on their page.

Here's the thing nobody tells business owners: your website isn't a brochure. It's a salesperson that never sleeps, never calls in sick, and is currently talking to your customers right now, this second, while you're reading this. The only question is whether it's a good salesperson or a bad one.

Let's fix that.

1. Your Homepage Has One Job. Most Homepages Try to Do Ten.

I can't count how many homepages I've opened where, after reading the whole thing, I still couldn't tell you what the business actually does. There's a slider with five rotating images. There's a mission statement. There's a “Welcome to Our Website” headline (please, never this). There's an icon grid of eight services. And nowhere, in any of that, is there a clear answer to the one question every visitor actually has:

“Is this for me, and what do I do next?”

A homepage that converts does three things, and only three things, above the fold:

- States clearly what you do and who it's for
- Gives the visitor one obvious next step (a button, a form, a phone number — one, not four competing for attention)
- Builds a shred of trust immediately (a real photo, a specific result, a recognizable client name)

That's it. Everything else — your full service list, your history, your team bios — belongs further down the page or on its own page entirely. The homepage's job is to get someone to take one step forward. Not to tell your whole story in one screen.

If you want a quick gut check: show your homepage to someone who's never seen it, for five seconds, then take it away. Ask them what the business does and what they'd do next. If they can't answer both, you've found your problem.

2. Speed Is a Feature, Not a Technical Detail

This is the one business owners underestimate the most, because it's invisible until it's costing them money.

A website that takes several seconds to load isn't just “a bit slow.” It's actively pushing customers toward a competitor. People don't consciously think “this is taking too long, I'll leave.” They just leave. The frustration happens beneath the level of a decision — it's a reflex.

I don't start by redesigning a slow site. I start by finding out what's actually responsible for the delay, because “make it faster” isn't a plan — it's a wish. In practice, that means checking, in order:

- **Images first.** Almost always the biggest culprit. A single unoptimized hero image can be heavier than the entire rest of the page combined.
- **Third-party scripts.** Chat widgets, old tracking pixels, marketing tools installed once and never removed — each one adds a network request before the page is usable.
- **Render-blocking resources.** Fonts and stylesheets that force the browser to wait before showing anything at all.
- **Hosting.** Cheap shared hosting from a decade-old provider is still shockingly common, and no amount of front-end polish fixes a slow server.

I've rebuilt sites where the entire “problem” the client thought they had — low leads, high bounce rate, poor conversions — turned out to be almost entirely explained by that first item: a homepage loading megabytes of unoptimized images and unnecessary scripts before it showed anything at all.

A fast website tells a visitor, before they've read a single word, that this business is competent and takes them seriously. A slow one tells them the opposite, and it does it instantly.

3. Mobile Isn't a Version of Your Site. For Most Businesses, It's the Main Event.

For most small businesses, a large share of visitors are on a phone. Not “checking” your site on a phone as a secondary experience — that phone screen is their entire experience of your business, full stop.

And yet I still regularly see sites where the desktop version is polished and the mobile version is an afterthought: text too small to read without zooming, buttons too close together to tap accurately, a contact form that requires horizontal scrolling to fill out.

Think about what that says to a visitor. It says “we built this for ourselves, not for you.” Nobody says that out loud, of course. They just leave and call the next business on the list — one whose site didn't fight them.

The fix isn't complicated in principle: design for the phone first, then adapt upward to larger screens, rather than the other way around. In practice it takes real attention, because a layout that looks great squeezed onto a laptop can quietly become a mess on a five-inch screen. But this is one area where the return on getting it right is enormous, precisely because so many competitors still get it wrong.

4. Trust Signals Do the Convincing You're Not There to Do

Here's something worth sitting with: your website has to do, entirely on its own, the same job a good salesperson does in person — building enough trust that a stranger is willing to hand over their money or their contact information.

A salesperson does that through tone of voice, body language, answering questions on the spot. Your website has none of that. All it has is what you choose to put on the page. Which means every trust signal you're not using is a gap your competitor's website is probably filling instead.

The trust signals that actually move the needle:

- **Real testimonials**, ideally with a name and, if possible, a photo — not “Great service! — J.D.”
- **Specific results**, not vague claims. “Increased their online orders by 34% in two months” beats “we help businesses grow” every time, because specificity is what makes a claim believable.
- **Visible proof of legitimacy** — years in business, number of clients served, certifications, recognizable logos of past clients if you have permission to use them.
- **A real human face**. A photo of you or your team, even a simple one, does more for trust than most business owners expect.

None of this needs to be flashy. It needs to be specific and true. Vague reassurance convinces nobody; a specific detail convinces almost everyone.

5. If a Stranger Can't Find “What Does This Cost” or “How Do I Start,” You've Lost Them

This one sounds obvious once it's said out loud, and yet it's one of the most common problems I run into: a visitor who's genuinely interested has no idea how to actually become a customer.

Sometimes there's no pricing at all, and no way to get an estimate without booking a call — which is a real barrier for anyone still comparing options. Sometimes the contact form is buried three clicks deep, or it asks for so much information upfront that people abandon it. Sometimes there's simply no clear “here's what happens if you reach out” — no next-step clarity at all.

Every point of friction between “I'm interested” and “I've taken action” costs you a percentage of your visitors. Not all of them, but enough to matter, especially at scale. Ask yourself honestly: if you were a stranger who'd never heard of your business, would you know exactly what to do thirty seconds after landing on your site? If the answer is “probably, with a bit of hunting,” that hunting is losing you customers you never even find out about.

The businesses that win here aren't necessarily the cheapest or the best. They're the ones that make it easiest to say yes.

6. Your Website Should Answer the Questions Customers Actually Ask You

Every business has a handful of questions that come up constantly — on the phone, in emails, in person. “Do you serve my area?” “How long does this take?” “What's included?” “Do you offer X?”

If those answers only live in your head, or in the memory of whoever answers your phone, you're forcing every single visitor to either guess, or contact you just to ask a question that a hundred people before them also asked. Some percentage of those visitors won't bother reaching out. They'll assume the answer is unfavorable, or they'll just move on to a competitor whose site already told them.

A website that answers real, specific questions — through an FAQ section, through clear service descriptions, through short pages that address common concerns directly — does two things at once. It removes friction for the customers who were going to buy anyway, and it captures the ones who would have quietly given up rather than ask.

This is also, by the way, one of the most underrated ways a site builds trust: it demonstrates that you understand your customer's actual situation, before they've even spoken to you.

7. If You Can't Measure What Happens After Someone Clicks, You're Guessing

This is the one most business owners skip entirely, and it's the one that turns “I think the website is working” into “I know exactly what it's doing for me.”

Most small business sites have no real measurement in place beyond a visitor counter, if that. Nobody's tracking which page a customer filled out the contact form on, which button they clicked before calling, or which service page actually leads to paying work versus which one just gets browsed.

Without that, every decision about your website is a guess dressed up as an opinion. You can't tell whether a change helped, hurt, or did nothing. You can't tell which of your services is actually generating interest. You're flying on instinct when the data to fly on instruments is entirely available and usually cheap to set up.

At a minimum, a business should be able to answer:

- Which pages people land on, and which ones they leave from
- Which specific action (form submission, phone click, booking) each conversion came from
- Which traffic source — search, social, referral — actually produces customers, not just visitors

None of this requires anything exotic. It's analytics, properly configured events on your key actions, and a habit of actually looking at the numbers occasionally rather than setting it up once and forgetting it exists. But the businesses that do this consistently make better decisions than the ones running entirely on gut feeling — because they're the only ones who actually know what's working.

8. Nobody Updates Their Website, and That's Exactly Why You Should

Quick note before this one: it's listed last, but that's just where it landed once I'd written the other seven — not a ranking. If anything, this is one of the most important items on this list, precisely because it's the easiest to ignore and the one almost nobody actually does.

Here's the last one, and it's less about any single feature and more about an ongoing habit that almost nobody keeps up.

Most small business websites get built once and then left alone for years. The “latest news” section still shows something from three years ago. The services listed don't match what the business actually offers anymore. A visitor who notices this — and people do notice, even if only subconsciously — starts to wonder what else about the business might be out of date.

A website that's clearly maintained — updated content, current information, small visible signs of activity — signals something important without saying it directly: this business is alive, active, and paying attention. That's a meaningfully different impression than a site that looks like it was built once and forgotten.

You don't need to overhaul your website every month. But checking it every so often, updating anything stale, and treating it as a living part of your business rather than a one-time project puts you ahead of the majority of your competitors by default — simply because most of them won't bother.

Putting This Together

None of these eight things, on their own, will transform a business overnight. But they compound. A homepage with a clear message, that loads fast, that works properly on a phone, backed by real trust signals, with an obvious next step, that answers real questions, that's actually measured, and is visibly kept up to date — that's a fundamentally different experience than the average small business website. And your customers are comparing you to that average, whether they realize it or not.

The businesses that get this right aren't necessarily spending more money. They're just paying attention to details that most competitors overlook, either because nobody pointed them out, or because “we'll get to the website eventually” has been the plan for the last two years.

If you've read through this and recognized your own site in one or two of these points, that's normal — I see some version of at least three or four of these on almost every site I review for the first time. The point isn't to feel behind. It's to know exactly what to fix, and in what order.

If you'd like a second pair of eyes on your specific site — what's working, what's quietly costing you customers, and what I'd prioritize fixing first — feel free to reach out. I'm happy to take a look.

— *Romany*